

Giving your child a time-out and wondering if it's a bad idea

9 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Time-out isn't harmful in itself. Whether it helps or backfires comes down to **how you run it**: waiting for calm, then following through on what you first asked.

THE GOAL

You want this to land as a lesson rather than a blow-up. If anyone is getting hurt, stop that first, before anything else.

CHECKLIST

Your child has just done the thing that means time-out, right now.

- ☐ If what's happening is dangerous or someone's getting hurt, stop it first, before anything else.
- ☐ If it's dangerous, already hurt someone, or breaks a rule they know, **skip the warning** and go straight to time-out.
- ☐ If it's about not doing what you asked, give one calm heads-up: name the behavior and say what happens if it continues.
- ☐ If they still haven't done it after a few seconds, follow through right away instead of repeating the warning.
- ☐ Say what they did in one short sentence, then walk them to the time-out spot without extra conversation.
- ☐ Start a timer sized to their age, not just a token few seconds.
- ☐ If they get up before it's over, walk them back without a word and restart the timer.
- ☐ If they cry or protest while they're in it, leave them be unless something needs your attention right away.
- ☐ Wait until they're calm, **not just until the timer ends**, before you let them out.
- ☐ The moment they're calm, have them do the original thing you asked, right then.
- ☐ Once that's done, go back to talking with them normally, you don't need to bring it up again.
- ☐ If you're reaching for time-out again and again today for the same thing, that's your cue to look at what's setting it off.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 A well-known 'time-out is harmful' piece got its scary headline from an editor, not its own authors.
- 2 Time-out works better when you **wait for your child to be calm** than when you stop right at the timer. It works better still when you immediately follow through on what you first asked.
- 3 Time-out works by taking away your attention and the things your child likes while it lasts.

What the 'time-out is harmful' claim gets wrong

KNOW

A well-known 'time-out is harmful' piece got its scary headline from an editor, not its own authors.

The piece's own authors have since said, in their own words, that wasn't the conclusion they'd reached. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Time-out is among a very small number of discipline tools with real evidence behind it, and pediatric guidance recommends it outright.

It's research-backed, but correctly running it takes more care than a quick online summary usually shows. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

How you run time-out, more than whether you use it, decides whether it strains your bond with your child. Done the researched way, it goes with **less insecurity** in that relationship.

The finding doesn't prove time-out causes closeness, only that doing it the researched way tracks with a more secure relationship instead. [Source 3](#)

Timing, warnings and follow-through

DO

Time-out works better when you **wait for your child to be calm** than when you stop right at the timer. It works better still when you immediately follow through on what you first asked.

Ending on the timer skips the part that actually teaches anything: doing the thing you originally asked, right after. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Time-out works by taking away your attention and the things your child likes while it lasts.

The upset you see is your child missing what time-out removes, and that alone is enough to change what they do next time. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

Don't assume you need to warn every time. For an already-known family rule, official guidance **skips the warning entirely**.

It only skips the warning for things they already understand are automatic time-out territory, not for everyday requests. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

The same guidance that recommends time-out as effective also warns it gets overused, and says it **works best as part of** a bigger set of approaches.

Relying on time-out for everything is exactly the overuse pattern this same guidance flags as the problem. [Source 5](#)

Details you don't need to get exactly right

KNOW

A lot of the specific time-out rules floating around go further than the research supports.

Parenting sources often state these specific rules with **more confidence than the evidence gives them**. [Source 6](#)

DON'T

Don't stress over finding the exact right time-out spot or signal; research hasn't settled which works best.

So there's no evidence a particular spot or signal works better than another you'd pick yourself. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Using time-out damages your bond with your child and makes them feel rejected.

ACTUALLY

The study built specifically to test this directly **found the opposite**: children whose time-out matched the research-backed approach scored lower on relationship insecurity, not higher. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://drdansiegel.com/you-said-what-about-time-outs/>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4179870/>
3. <http://web.archive.org/web/20250817033207/https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/the-british-journal-of-psychiatry/article/timeout-under-scrutiny-examining-the-relationships-among-the-discipline-strategy-timeout-child-wellbeing-and-attachment-and-exposure-to-adversity/979BF190B7E433C6BEFFA25A2245BABF>
4. <https://www.restoredcdc.org/www.cdc.gov/parenting-toddlers/time-out/index.html>

5. <https://www.healthychildren.org/English/family-life/family-dynamics/communication-discipline/Pages/Time-Outs-101.aspx>
6. https://digitalcommons.usu.edu/psych_stures/17/

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Praise, rewards and consequences at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)